

Nigeria Artificial Intelligence Industry Collective

NIGERIA AI COLLECTIVE COMMUNITY MONTHLY DIGEST

MONTH ENDING APRIL 2026

Explore the Latest from Our Community: Key Resources, Insights, and Hot Topics in AI

This Month's Highlights:

VP Shettima Launches AI University Innovation Pods (UniPods) at UNILAG, Declares Nigeria Ready to Lead

Africa in AI

DSI group convened representatives from 20 media and civil society organisations

CJID

democratise access to AI skills for greater equality by launching the AI Advocacy Project

Nigeria Moves

Toward Comprehensive AI Regulation as National Digital Economy Bill Nears Passage

InnoPower Africa

and Luma Learn AI Target One Million Learners Across Africa

Nigeria Deploys AI Surveillance Infrastructure

to Plateau State

Meta Debuts Muse Spark, Its Most Powerful AI Model

Google Releases Gemma 4

Open-Weight AI for Advanced Reasoning

OpenAI Confirmed at \$852 Billion Valuation as ChatGPT

Reaches 900 Million Weekly Users.

Nigeria National AI Strategy 2 years Impact Story and legacy

Papers

African Voices Nigeria: 2500 hours of ethically sourced speech data for four Nigerian Languages

Bridging the AI Governance Gap: Ethical and Regulatory Imperatives for Generative AI in Nigeria

Accent-Aware Text-to-Speech for Nigerian English: Building Inclusive Voice AI from Community-Curated Data

Opportunities

Deep Learning Indaba 2026

Africa AI Safety Prize Competition

The Visa Africa Fintech Accelerator Program

2026 (Cohort 6)

Coollest Projects Online by the Raspberry Pi Foundation

NigComSat Accelerator Program

2026 (Cohort 3.0) for Nigerian Startups

Join the AI Community of Practice

Upcoming Events

IndabaX Nigeria 2026

CIO Africa Tech & AI Summit - Lagos 2026

Thoughtful Leadership

Vice President Kashim Shettima

Dr. Bosun Tijani

Prof. Olayinka David-West

VP Shettima Launches AI University Innovation Pods at UNILAG



On 7th April 2026, Vice President Kashim Shettima inaugurated Nigeria's first AI University Innovation Pod (UniPod) at the University of Lagos, declaring that Nigeria is prepared to lead the entire African continent in the deployment of Artificial Intelligence. Represented by the Deputy Chief of Staff to the President, Senator Ibrahim Hassan Hadejia, the Vice President described AI as 'humanity's most powerful general-purpose technology' and challenged Nigerian universities to evolve from centres of instruction into platforms for production, enterprise, and national development.

The UniPod initiative is a partnership between the Federal Government, UNDP, TETFund, the University of Lagos, and the Lagos State Government. The hubs are designed as innovation spaces where students, researchers, and industry practitioners co-create AI solutions that respond directly to Nigerian economic realities. The Vice President confirmed plans to scale similar pods to universities across the country, calling it 'a system we intend to scale, sustain, and subject to results.' UNDP's Resident Representative in Nigeria, Ms Elsie Attafuah, described the initiative as one that 'connects knowledge to opportunity, innovation to enterprise, and talent to national prosperity.'





Nigeria Moves Toward Comprehensive AI Regulation

Nigeria is on the cusp of becoming one of the first African nations to enact comprehensive AI legislation. The National Digital Economy and E-Governance Bill introduces a risk-based regulatory framework for AI systems in both the public and private sectors, with NITDA positioned as the central authority.

Developers and deployers would be required to implement governance measures proportional to the potential impact of their systems, covering fairness, transparency, non-discrimination, and human oversight.

Minister of Communications, Innovation and Digital Economy, Dr Bosun Tijani, confirmed at the CMC Connect Crisis Management Conference in Lagos that Nigeria's National AI Strategy is fully developed and awaits legislative backing expected within weeks.

He also revealed that Nigeria has developed a government-backed large language model designed to

understand and communicate in Hausa, Igbo, and Yoruba alongside English - a significant step toward ensuring Africa's linguistic diversity is embedded in Nigeria's AI infrastructure from the outset.



Nigeria's National AI Strategy Turns Two and the Numbers Speak



Two years into Nigeria's National AI Strategy, the question is no longer whether the country is serious about AI. The numbers answer that.

At a commemoration ceremony held in Abuja during Microsoft AI Skills Week 2026, graced by the Honourable Minister of Communications, Innovation and Digital Economy, Dr Bosun Tijani, alongside key stakeholders and strategy pillar leads, the NAIS at 2 Impact Story: Ecosystem Compilation was officially launched. It documents what two years of focused national execution actually looks like; 700,000+ Nigerians reached through AI skills and talent development. \$1.85 billion in AI-related investment commitments. 120+ active AI startups, a 3.4x growth in the ecosystem. The launch of N-ATLAS, Africa's first government-backed multimodal, multilingual large language model. And growing national coordination through institutions like NCAIR and the Nigeria AI Collective.

It was stated that not every activity captured in the report could be directly attributed to the Strategy document itself. Rather, it reflects the broader understanding that a strong and credible national AI strategy can help create the conditions for innovation, collaboration, sustainable growth, investment, ecosystem participation, and global visibility. Download the full NAIS at 2 Impact Story compilation here: https://bit.ly/NAIS-2_Report





InnoPower Africa and Luma Learn AI Target One Million Learners

On 10th April 2026, InnoPower Africa and Luma Learn AI announced a strategic collaboration to expand access to AI tools and education across Africa, targeting one million learners.

The partnership adopts a train-the-trainer model, equipping professionals to support MSMEs and integrating AI tools into training programmes for educators and entrepreneurs across the ECOWAS sub-region.

Emil Ekiyor, Founder and CEO of InnoPower Africa, stated plainly: 'Africa is not waiting for technology to arrive; Africans are already the most active AI users in the world. What we need is structured access, training, and infrastructure.

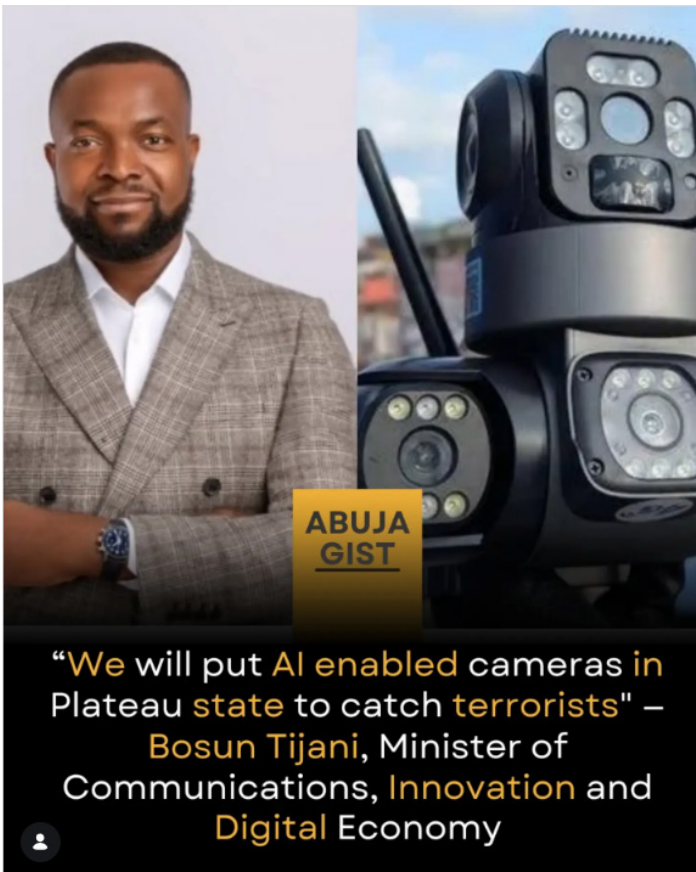
That is exactly what this partnership builds.' The initiative will raise an initial \$250,000 to scale access to AI learning

tools across ECOWAS, targeting students, teachers, families, and MSMEs - with emphasis on practical AI applications.

The announcement reinforces Nigeria's emerging role as the strategic hub for AI education deployment across West Africa.



Nigeria to Deploy AI Surveillance Infrastructure to Plateau State



Following a series of security incidents in Plateau State, President Bola Ahmed Tinubu directed the deployment of AI-enabled surveillance infrastructure across the state, beginning with Jos.

Minister Bosun Tijani confirmed that a network of AI-powered cameras would be installed, noting that similar systems are already operational in Lagos and Enugu with documented results. The minister stated: 'We will have a network of artificial intelligence-enabled cameras all over the state, starting with Jos.'

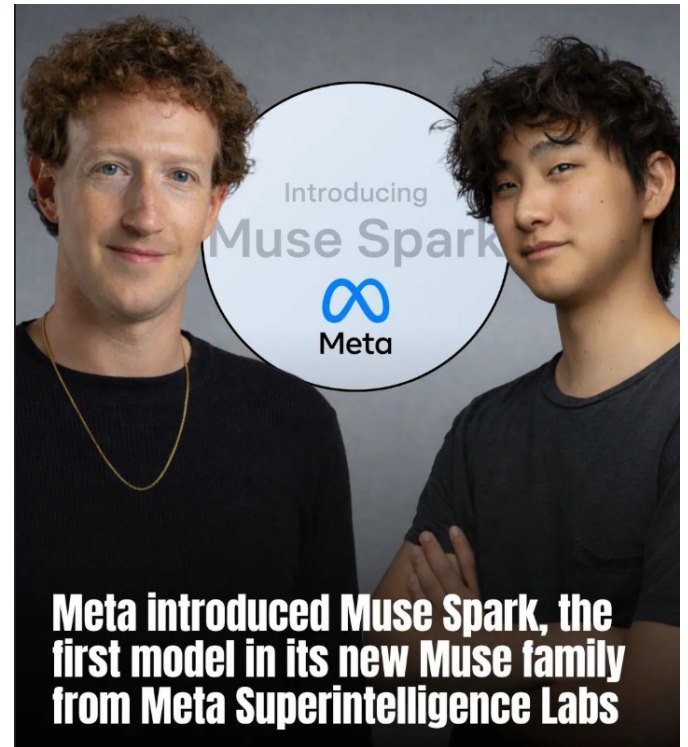
The initiative marks a notable expansion of Nigeria's deployment of AI in public administration - from business registration (the Corporate Affairs Commission now processes close to 10,000 registrations daily via AI) and digital governance, to active public safety infrastructure. It signals a government that is progressively embedding AI into the architecture of state function, though it also raises important questions about governance, accountability, and civil liberties that Nigeria's emerging AI regulatory framework will need to address.

Meta Debuts Muse Spark: Its Most Powerful AI Model to Date

Meta unveiled Muse Spark on 8th April 2026 - the first major AI model from its Meta Superintelligence Labs, built on rebuilt infrastructure that significantly reduces compute requirements.

The model already powers Meta AI and will be integrated into Facebook, Instagram, WhatsApp, Messenger, and Meta's Ray-Ban smart glasses.

For Nigerian users, the WhatsApp integration is particularly significant: with WhatsApp serving as Nigeria's primary communication and commerce platform, an AI model embedded at the interface level represents a material shift in how millions of Nigerians will interact with AI - not as a deliberate choice, but as a feature of tools already in daily use. Meta's \$115-135 billion AI capital expenditure for 2026 signals this is a long-term strategic commitment.



Google Releases Gemma 4: Open-Weight AI for Advanced Reasoning



Gemma 4
Our most intelligent
open models



On 2nd April 2026, Google released Gemma 4 - its most intelligent open-weight model to date, purpose-built for advanced reasoning and agentic workflows. With over 400 million downloads across the Gemma family and a developer community of over 100,000 model variants, Gemma 4 is released under an Apache 2.0 licence - freely available for commercial and research use.

For Nigerian AI builders, this represents a significant practical resource: a high-performance foundation model available at no cost, enabling local fine-tuning on Nigerian-specific datasets without dependence on expensive proprietary APIs.

OpenAI at \$852 Billion Valuation as ChatGPT Reaches 900 Million Weekly Users



OpenAI has confirmed a funding valuation of \$852 billion - making it the most valuable private company in history - while ChatGPT now serves 900 million weekly users globally. The global AI market is projected to reach \$539 billion in 2026, up from \$390 billion in 2025. For Nigeria's AI ecosystem, these figures frame an important strategic challenge: the concentration of AI capability and capital in a small number of US-based firms accelerates a dependency dynamic where African users generate value that flows to platforms with limited local infrastructure commitment. Nigeria's forthcoming AI legislation is in part a deliberate policy response to this dynamic.

Building Digital Resilience: Inside a Workshop on Ethical AI and Data Protection



In March, a two-day Digital Resilience and Ethical AI workshop took place and convened representatives from 20 media and civil society organisations. This workshop was organised by the Data Shield for Impact (DSI) group, a CSOs community of practice put together by the [Centre for Journalism Innovation and Development](#) under the [Nigeria AI](#)

Collective.

The training addressed the growing need for data protection systems and the responsible use of emerging technologies as organisations increasingly digitise their operations. It focused on building practical skills in digital security, ethical AI adoption, and data governance to reduce organisational risk and improve digital resilience.

Across both days, participants engaged in sessions covering foundations of digital security, data back-up systems, encryption, the Nigeria Data Protection Act (NDPA) 2023, and ethical AI use in organisational settings.

The workshop concluded with participants equipped to strengthen internal digital security practices, apply data protection principles, and develop ethical AI frameworks.

Home-grown Research with Global Recognition

Papers: [African Voices Nigeria: 2500 hours of ethically sourced speech data for four Nigerian Languages](#)

Authors: Ife Adebara, Oluwaseun Nifemi, Rashidat Damilola Sikiru, Olanrewaju Israel Lawal, Ololade Anjuwon, Olubayo Adekanmbi, Anthony Soronnadi, John Emeka Eze, Ewezu Ngim Ngim.

This paper was presented at the proceedings of the 7th Workshop on African Natural Language Processing (AfricaNLP 2026), held in Rabat, Morocco as part of EACL 2026, where it stood out as one of three papers awarded Best Paper, a recognition that highlights both its technical depth and its broader impact on the future of African language technologies.

The authors introduce African Voices Nigeria, one of the largest and most carefully designed speech datasets for African languages to date: 2,500 hours of audio from over 2,800 speakers, covering Hausa, Igbo, Yoruba, and Nigerian Pidgin. But beyond scale, the project addresses a deeper problem in speech AI, most existing datasets rely heavily on scripted or read speech, which fails to reflect how people actually speak in real life.

African Voices takes a different approach. It prioritizes spontaneous, real-world speech, capturing natural variation in accent, tone, dialect, code-switching, and conversational flow. The dataset spans everyday domains like healthcare, agriculture, business, and daily communication, making it far more representative of how speech technologies are used in practice. Each recording is paired with rich demographic metadata, age, gender, education, enabling researchers to study not just performance, but fairness and bias across different speaker groups.

On the technical side, the paper provides baseline results for automatic speech recognition (ASR) using Whisper-based models. The findings reinforce a familiar but critical point: even strong multilingual systems struggle with African languages, especially those with tonal complexity, dialectal diversity, and high rates of code-switching. However, the results also show that fine-tuning on high-quality, locally grounded data dramatically improves performance, underlining the importance of datasets like African Voices for closing the gap.

What truly distinguishes this work is its emphasis on ethical data governance. The dataset is built with informed consent, human-in-the-loop anonymization, and structured access controls, treating speech data not just as a technical resource, but as something deeply tied to identity, privacy, and community ownership. In a field where data collection has often been extractive, this project offers a model for responsible, participatory AI development in African contexts.

Stepping back, the paper makes a clear and timely argument: building effective speech technologies for Africa is not just a modeling problem, it is a data problem shaped by culture, diversity, and ethics. By releasing African Voices as an open, well-documented resource grounded in real-world language use, the authors provide both a foundation for robust ASR research and a call to action for the community to invest in more inclusive, representative speech data. In doing so, the work moves the conversation forward, from simply including African languages in AI systems to building them on data that truly reflects how Africans speak.

Home-grown Research with Global Recognition

Papers: [Bridging the AI Governance Gap: Ethical and Regulatory Imperatives for Generative AI in Nigeria](#)

Authors: Oluwatayofunmi Durodola

This paper examines the rapid uptake of generative AI tools across Nigeria's education, media, and business sectors, alongside the absence of a coherent governance framework to guide their use. It argues that this gap is already shaping real-world risks rather than being a future concern.

It highlights key pressure points: in education, AI use is raising concerns around academic integrity; in politics, AI-generated misinformation and synthetic media are intensifying information disorder; and in the economy, productivity gains are accompanied by widening digital skills gaps and potential job displacement.

Comparing Nigeria's emerging efforts with more established frameworks in the EU, US, and China, the paper finds that current initiatives, including the National AI Strategy and related institutions, remain fragmented and weakly coordinated. It cautions against directly importing external models without local adaptation.

The paper concludes by calling for a national AI ethics framework, stronger data protection regimes, investment in local research capacity, and improved public understanding of AI risks. It argues that governance must move beyond risk management to actively shape innovation in line with Nigeria's socio-economic priorities.

Papers: [Accent-Aware Text-to-Speech for Nigerian English: Building Inclusive Voice AI from Community-Curated Data](#)

Authors: Christianah Oyewale, Benjamin Ogbonna

Venue: NeurIPS 2025 - Neural Information Processing Systems Conference, San Diego, USA (December 2025)

Text-to-speech systems are increasingly embedded in navigation apps, accessibility tools, customer service platforms, and educational technology. The problem for Nigerian users is that mainstream systems are predominantly trained on American and British English speakers, producing speech that sounds foreign and is often difficult for Nigerian listeners to follow - a real barrier for tools intended to serve the Nigerian public.

This paper, published at NeurIPS 2025 - one of the world's most prestigious AI research conferences - presents a text-to-speech system built specifically for Nigerian-accented English. The researchers built their own community-curated dataset by recording speakers from Nigeria's three major ethnic groups (Yoruba, Igbo, and Hausa) reading texts on history, politics, and education. After careful transcription and segmentation, this produced over 4,000 paired audio-text samples that authentically capture Nigerian speech patterns.

Using the StyleTTS2 architecture and phoneme-level processing, the model generates speech reflecting accent characteristics and expressive qualities such as pitch and prosody. In human evaluation, approximately 87% of synthesised outputs were rated as faithful to the intended accent and natural in tone, with a word error rate of 12.4% - indicating strong practical usability. The paper reinforces a broader principle of direct relevance to Nigeria's AI ecosystem: locally sourced, community-curated data is the critical ingredient, not larger models or more compute.

Opportunities and Events

An overview of upcoming events, available funding, proposal invitations, and other timely opportunities shared within the Community.

Deep Learning Indaba 2026



[Deep Learning Indaba 2026 Is Coming to Nigeria!!!](#)

For the first time in its eight-year history, the Deep Learning Indaba is coming to Nigeria. The 8th edition of Africa's most prestigious annual AI and machine learning gathering will be hosted at Pan-Atlantic University (PAU) in Lagos, from 2nd to 7th August 2026.

Since its founding in 2017, the Indaba has convened Africa's AI community across the continent, in South Africa, Kenya, Senegal, Tunisia, and most recently Rwanda in 2025. Its arrival in Nigeria is a landmark moment, signalling the country's growing centrality in shaping the continent's AI future. The week-long event brings together researchers, practitioners,

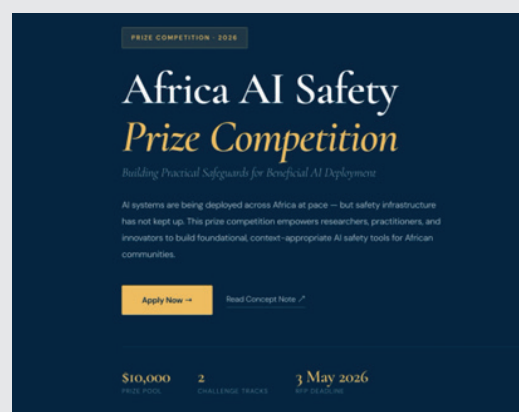
students, and policymakers for world-class learning, collaboration, and research exchange, drawing participants from across Africa and beyond.

The Indaba team is actively inviting sponsors and partners to help make DLI2026 accessible and impactful. For a gathering of this scale coming to Nigeria for the first time, local institutional support is both a practical necessity and a statement of commitment to the African AI ecosystem. Organisations interested in partnership and sponsorship opportunities are encouraged to reach out through the official Deep Learning Indaba at [Deep Learning Indaba 2026](#)

Africa AI Safety Prize Competition

Deadline – 3rd May 2026

The [Africa AI Safety Prize Competition](#), launched by the Centre for AI Security and Access, invites applications from researchers, practitioners, and innovators to develop practical AI safety solutions tailored to African contexts. With a total prize pool of \$10,000 across two challenge tracks, the competition supports tools and methods for monitoring AI harms at the community level and evaluating AI systems for real-world



Opportunities and Events

deployment. Open to applicants across Africa and beyond, the initiative emphasizes locally grounded, actionable approaches that can strengthen safety, reduce risk, and build capacity where AI systems are already in use. Applications close on May 3, 2026, with support from partners including AI4D Africa, Masakhane African Languages Hub, and the African Hub on AI Safety, Peace and Security.

Cooperative AI – Research Grant (2025)



Deadline - May 17, 2026

The [Visa Africa Fintech Accelerator Program 2026](#) (Cohort 6) invites seed to Series A startups building fintech solutions across Africa to apply. Backed by Visa Inc., the program supports ventures in payments, embedded finance, and financial infrastructure with access to mentorship, Visa's technology, and structured scaling support. Selected startups also gain investor and partner exposure, culminating in a Demo Day.

The accelerator is part of Visa's broader effort to advance Africa's digital economy by helping startups move from traction to scale.

Cooler Projects Online by the Raspberry Pi Foundation



Deadline - May 27th, 2026

Submissions are now open for [Cooler Projects Online](#), a global showcase by the Raspberry Pi Foundation inviting young people aged 18 and under to share their digital creations with the world. From AI and games to apps, websites, and hardware projects, the programme celebrates creativity and innovation across all skill levels.

Open to participants worldwide—individually or in teams—the initiative provides a platform to present projects, gain feedback, and join a global community of young tech creators.

Opportunities and Events

NigComSat Accelerator Program 2026 (Cohort 3.0) for Nigerian Startups



Deadline - Not Specified

The [NigComSat Accelerator Programme 2026](#) (Cohort 3.0), launched by Nigerian Communications Satellite Limited, invites applications from Nigerian startups building innovative solutions across technology, space, and digital transformation. Designed to support high-potential ventures, the

programme offers mentorship, visibility, and access to strategic networks to help founders scale and compete globally.

Open to startups with a functional prototype or MVP, the accelerator spans sectors from AI and telecommunications to agriculture, climate, and space technologies, prioritizing solutions with strong growth potential and real-world impact. Through this initiative, NigComSat aims to strengthen Nigeria's innovation ecosystem by equipping startups with the tools and exposure needed to drive national development and global relevance.

Join the AI Community of Practice

Deadline - Not Specified

The [Centre for Journalism Innovation and Development \(CJID\)](#), through the [Nigeria AI Collective](#), is pleased to announce an open call for applications to join its AI Community of Practice (CoP), a growing, cross-sector network designed to deepen awareness, collaboration, learning, and innovation around the responsible use of artificial intelligence in Nigeria.

Building on over a year of collaboration across journalism, civil society, academia, and technology, this call advances a more inclusive and accountable AI ecosystem. It has supported civil society advocacy efforts and trained lecturers and media professionals across Nigeria to integrate AI into teaching, research, and newsroom practice.

The AI Community of Practice is open to journalists, civil society organisations, researchers and academics, as well as policy and governance actors.

A dark blue poster with white and green text. At the top left is the logo of the Federal Ministry of Communications, Innovation & Digital Economy. At the top right is the Nigeria AI Collective logo. The main title 'Call for Applications' is in large white font, with 'AI Community of Practice' in green below it. A megaphone icon is on the right. A QR code is at the bottom right with the text 'Scan to Register'. The text describes the CoP as a platform for engagement and lists who can join: journalists, civil society, researchers, and policy actors. It also states the goal is to create an inclusive and meaningful space for responsible AI. At the bottom, it says 'Implemented by: CJID' with the CJID logo.

Call for Applications
AI Community of Practice

The Centre for Journalism Innovation and Development, through the Nigeria AI Collective, is inviting applications in its AI Community of Practice.

The AI Community of Practice (CoP) is a platform designed to create an open, continuous forum for engagement, while connecting diverse media and civil society actors with Nigeria's AI ecosystem.

Who can join?

The Community of Practice is open to:

- Journalists and media professionals
- Civil society organisations
- Researchers and academics in the information and communication ecosystem.
- Policy actors and governance practitioners

The goal is to create a space that is both inclusive and meaningful, where participation is driven by interest, curiosity, and commitment to responsible AI.

Implemented by: **CJID**

Upcoming Events

An overview of upcoming events, available funding, proposal invitations, and other timely opportunities shared within the Community.

1. IndabaX Nigeria 2026

Date: 11th - 14th May 2026

Location: University of Ibadan, Nigeria (Hybrid - In-person and Virtual)

Nigeria's premier annual machine learning and AI gathering. This year's theme is 'Building Scalable AI That Works: From Research to Deployment in Resource-Constrained Environments' - shifting the conversation from unlimited-compute possibilities to what is achievable and impactful within Nigeria's real-world constraints. Accepted papers will be published in the Proceedings of Machine Learning Research (PMLR), Volume 319, indexed in Scopus and DBLP. Attendance is free. A key event for every member of the Nigeria AI Collective community involved in AI research, product development, or policy.

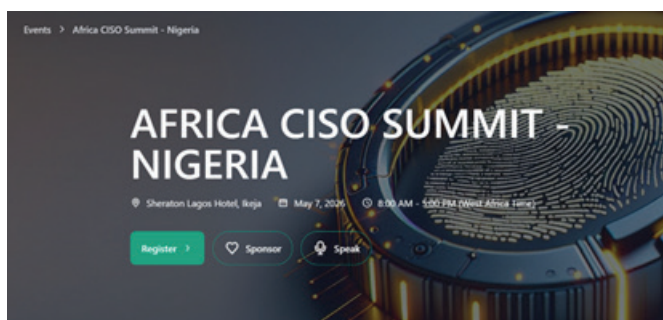


2. CIO Africa Tech & AI Summit - Lagos 2026

Date: 7th May 2026

Location: Lagos, Nigeria

As Africa's digital landscape continues to expand, so do the challenges and opportunities in cybersecurity. The Africa CISO Summit in Nigeria is a unique gathering that convenes over 200 of the continent's foremost cybersecurity leaders, decision-makers, and innovators. This May, we'll host an exclusive summit designed to address the pressing challenges faced by the region while highlighting the opportunities presented by emerging technologies and investment trends.



Thought Leadership



Vice President Kashim Shettima

Nigeria must not be passive, Shettima rallies youth for AI era

At the launch of the AI University Innovation Pod (UniPod), University of Lagos, 7th April 2026, said:

"Whether in agriculture, health, education, or finance, AI has the power to unlock new pathways for prosperity. But it will do so only if we design systems that are inclusive, equitable, and rooted in our values. I believe Nigeria is prepared to lead the whole African continent in this endeavour.

Our investments in digital public infrastructure, our embrace of innovation ecosystems, and our commitment to responsible AI governance all point to a singular goal - to make Nigeria not a consumer of imported technologies, but a producer of knowledge, innovation, and life-changing solutions."

Read more: punchng.com



Dr. Bosun Tijani

(Minister of Communications, Innovation & Digital Economy, Nigeria)

At the Crisis Management Advocacy Month Conference, Lagos, April 2026: "Nigeria now has a National Artificial Intelligence Strategy. We have also developed a government-backed large language model designed to understand and communicate in local languages such as Hausa, Igbo and Yoruba alongside English.

This is important to prevent the continent from being marginalised in the evolving AI ecosystem due to limited local data and language representation. Technology does not prevent crisis - but it dramatically improves our ability to manage it. Due to the environment we find ourselves in, crisis management has shifted from reaction to foresight, and AI is at the centre of that shift."

Read more: businessday.ng

Thought Leadership



Prof. Olayinka David-West

(Dean at Lagos Business School)

In this op-ed, Olayinka David-West examines how Nigeria's AI opportunity lies not in isolated use cases, but in scaling AI as a national productivity engine. She argues that while experimentation with AI has grown across sectors, the real value will be unlocked when these efforts move beyond fragmented pilots into coordinated, system-level adoption.

Central to this transition is the role of the Nigeria AI Scaling Hub, positioned as a platform to drive the integration of digital infrastructure, governance frameworks, and cross-sector collaboration. By connecting stakeholders across government, academia and industry, the Hub aims to create the enabling environment required for AI to deliver measurable economic and social impact.

The op-ed further underscores the importance of aligning policy, investment and talent development to ensure that AI solutions are not only innovative but also scalable and sustainable. This shift, from experimentation to execution will be critical in sectors such as agriculture, healthcare and education, where AI has the potential to significantly improve productivity and outcomes.

Ultimately, the piece calls for a more coordinated national approach to AI adoption, one that positions Nigeria to compete effectively in the global digital economy.

Read more: businessday.ng

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